

Exclusive focus in Akan and type flexibility*

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1. Introduction

Exclusive focus particles like *only* in English have flexible positions: as adverbial particles (*John **only**_{Adv} saw Mary*) or as adfocal particles (i.e., attaching to the focus, as in *John saw **only**_{Adfoc} Mary*), with the same truth conditions. This raises the question of whether exclusives are ambiguous between an A-quantifier and a D-quantifier (Horn 1969, Rooth 1985, 1992, Coppock and Beaver 2014, Yip and Adedjeji 2024, Yip 2026; cf. Renans 2017), dubbed *the type-ambiguity view* here; or uniformly as an A-quantifier, and the adfocal use is merely a syntactic “concord” phenomenon with a null exclusive operator OP_{EXCL} (Lee 2005, Quek and Hirsch 2017, Sun 2021, Bassi et al. 2022, Branan and Erlewine 2023, Aremu 2026; cf. Bayer 1996, *i.a.*), dubbed *the uniform operator view* here.

Akan (Kwa) is a language that provides crucial insight into this debate, where there are only adfocal exclusive particles without adverbial particles (see also Renans 2017 for Ga, a different Kwa language). There are two particles: *nkoaa* ‘only’ and *pɛ* ‘only’ (e.g., Thompson et al. 2022), which attach to the right of the focus, as illustrated in (1). Interestingly, they may even co-occur with the same focus association, giving rise to *exclusive doubling* (see Yip 2024, 2026 and references therein for a cross-linguistic landscape).

(1) Adfocal exclusive particles and exclusive doubling in Akan

- a. John hu-u [Mary]_F {**nkoaa/ pɛ/ nkoaa pɛ**}. (Object focus)
John see-PST Mary only only only only
‘John saw only Mary.’
- b. [John]_F {**nkoaa/ pɛ/ nkoaa pɛ**} hu-u Mary. (Subject focus)
John only only only only see-PST Mary
‘Only John saw Mary.’

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If the uniform operator view applied to Akan, there would only be null OP_{EXCL} carrying exclusive semantics, not the overt, adfocal *nkoaa* and *pɛ*, leading to a learnability puzzle on how null OP_{EXCL} can be acquired. On the contrary, this paper argues for the type-ambiguity view for Akan. We show in §2–3 that while both are adfocal particles, *nkoaa* allows for cross-categorical *association with focus* (henceforth AwF), whereas *pɛ* alone does not and must depend on *nkoaa* for AwF with VP and CP. Based on their scopal behavior, we further demonstrate in §4 that the locus of exclusive semantics is on the adfocal particles but not a null OP_{EXCL} . Coupled with the cross-categorical AwF, we propose a *type-flexible* analysis of exclusives in §5, and conclude the paper in §6 with implications on quantification.

2. The adfocal status of exclusive focus particles in Akan

We argue that both *nkoaa* and *pɛ* are adfocal particles. First, we have seen in (1) that the placement of *nkoaa* and *pɛ* changes with the focus position. Second, the focused constituents may undergo movement marked by the cleft focus marker *na* (see Boadi 1974, Grubic et al. 2019, cf. Titov 2019), leaving resumptive pronouns in object and subject positions, respectively (Korsah 2016, Yip and Ahenkorah 2023). Importantly, both *nkoaa* and *pɛ* obligatorily pied-pipe along with it, as in (2).¹

- (2) a. [Mary]_F {**nkoaa/ pɛ/ nkoaa pɛ**} na John hu-u no. (Object focus)
 Mary only only only only FOC John see-PST 3SG
 ‘It is only Mary that John saw.’
- b. [John]_F {**nkoaa/ pɛ/ nkoaa pɛ**} na ɛ-hu-u Mary. (Subject focus)
 John only only only only FOC 3SG-see-PST Mary
 ‘Only John saw Mary.’

Third, *nkoaa* and *pɛ* do not allow AwF at a distance as in (3), patterning with English adfocal but not adverbial *only* in (4).

- (3) a. #John ma-a [Mary]_F nwoma {**nkoaa/ pɛ/ nkoaa pɛ**}.
 John give-PST Mary book only only only only
 Int.: ‘John gave only Mary a book.’ (*IO focus)
 ONLY: ‘John gave Mary only a book.’ (DO focus)
- b. John ma-a [Mary]_F {**nkoaa/ pɛ/ nkoaa pɛ**} nwoma.
 John give-PST Mary only only only only book
 IO focus: ‘John gave only Mary a book.’
- (4) a. John **only**_{Adv} gave a book to [MARY]_F. (IO focus)
- b. #John gave **only**_{Advoc} a book to [MARY]_F.
 Int.: ‘The only person John gave a book to is Mary’ (*IO focus)
 ONLY: ‘The only thing John gave to Mary is a book.’ (DO focus)

¹The marker *na* is commonly analyzed as contributing exhaustivity. This exhaustivity is not-at-issue, in contrast to the at-issue exclusivity associated with *nkoaa* and *pɛ* which can be negated.

3. Cross-categorical association with focus (AwF)

The two particles differ in the categories of focus that they may associate with. While AwF with DP has already been observed, the crucial contrast concerns VP and CP focus. First, only *nkoaa* can associate with a VP focus, as illustrated in (5a). In contrast, *pɛ* in (5b) cannot target the VP and is instead interpreted as associating with the object DP. Strikingly, however, *pɛ* can target the VP when it is doubled with *nkoaa*, as in (5c).

- (5) Association with VP focus: The teacher asks: “What did Mary do yesterday? Did Mary read books?” You say: “No, ...”
- a. Mary [tu-u nwom]_F **nkoaa**.
 - b. #Mary [tu-u nwom]_F **pɛ**.
 - c. Mary [tu-u nwom]_F **nkoaa pɛ**.
Mary sing-PST song only only
- (a), (c): ‘Mary only sang songs (and did not read books).’ (VP focus)
(b): ONLY: ‘Mary sang only songs.’ (DP object focus)

The same is observed with ex-situ focus. As in (6), AwF with a VP with *na*-focus movement is acceptable with *nkoaa* and degraded with *pɛ*, which becomes acceptable again under doubling. Here, the VP is nominalized (as indicated by the epenthesized [-ATR] vowel, see Appah 2005, Essuman 2025) for focus movement, and yet *pɛ* still cannot associate with it, showing that it is not just a syntactic subcategorization issue.²

- (6) Same context as (5):
- a. [nwom tu-ɔ]_F **nkoaa** na Mary tu yɛ
 - b. ??[nwom tu-ɔ]_F **pɛ** na Mary tu yɛ.
 - c. [nwom tu-ɔ]_F **nkoaa pɛ** na Mary tu yɛ.
song sing-NMZL only only FOC Mary sing YE
- (a), (c): ‘It was only singing songs that Mary did.’ (VP focus)
(b): Strongly preferred: ‘It was singing only songs that Mary did.’ (DP object focus)

Second, AwF with CP exhibits the same asymmetry. As in (7a–b), CP focus is acceptable with *nkoaa* but not with *pɛ*, which again defaults to an embedded DP-object interpretation. Once again, doubling with *nkoaa* allows *pɛ* to associate with the CP, as in (7c).

- (7) AwF with CP: Both John and Mary did bad things. You are discussing whether the teacher knows. You say: “The teacher does not know that Mary smoked cigarette, ...”
- a. Takyini no nim [sɛ John wiaa phone]_F **nkoaa**.
 - b. #Takyini no nim [sɛ John wiaa phone]_F **pɛ**.
 - c. Takyini no nim [sɛ John wiaa phone]_F **nkoaa pɛ**.
teacher DET know COMP John stole phone only only
- (a), (c): ‘The teacher only knows John stole a phone.’ (CP focus)
(b): ONLY: ‘The teacher knows John only stole a phone.’ (embedded DP-obj. focus)

²VP movement leaves a verbal resumptive form *yɛ*. The nature of *yɛ* is subject to debate, see Kandybowicz (2015), Korsah et al. (2023) and references therein for discussion.

The same contrast persists in (8) with ex-situ CP, which requires a clausal determiner *no* ‘the’ (Korsah 2017, Bombi et al. 2019, Owusu 2022, 2025, *i.a.*) for focus movement. Like the case with nominalized VP, the DP layer of *no* on CP does not make standalone *pɛ*’s AwF with it possible, but doubling is required.

(8) *Same context as (7):*

- a. [sɛ John wiaa phone]_F no **nkoa** na takyini no nim.
 - b. #[sɛ John wiaa phone]_F no **pɛ** na takyini no nim.
 - c. [sɛ John wiaa phone]_F no **nkoa pɛ** na takyini no nim.
COMP John stole phone CD only only FOC teacher DET know
- (a), (c): ‘It is only “*John stole a phone*” that the teacher knows.’ (CP focus)
 (b): ONLY: ‘It is “*John stole only the phone*” that the teacher knows.’
 (embedded DP-obj. focus)

In summary, while *nkoa* is flexible and can associate with DP, VP, and CP foci, *pɛ* is restricted to DP focus when it appears alone. When the two particles are doubled, however, the full range of AwF possibilities becomes available again. We suggest that it is *nkoa* that determines the AwF in doubling cases, whereas *pɛ* is dependent on it. *Nkoa*’s pattern is reminiscent of the cross-categorical uses of the Akan determiner *no* ‘the’ (Owusu 2022, 2025), which attaches to both nominals and clauses (as we have seen above).³

4. Scopal behavior

We now turn to the scopal behavior of the two exclusive particles. First, they exhibit scopal ambiguities with modals. Wide scope readings over a permission modal are observed with *nkoa*, *pɛ*, and their doubling, as in (9) and evidenced by the felicitous continuation.

(9) Wide scope over modals: *Today is palm wine day. John can only bring palm wine and cannot bring other types of alcohol.* (only > ◇)

- a. John be-tumi de nsa fufuo **nkoa** a-ba.
- b. John be-tumi de nsa fufuo **pɛ** a-ba.
- c. John be-tumi de nsa fufuo **nkoa pɛ** a-ba.
John can use wine white only only PFV-come
(... Enti, ɔ ɛ-n-tumi n-fa nsa foforo biara ɛm-ba.)
therefore, 3SG 3SG-NEG-can NEG-take wine other rest NEG-come
(a-c): ‘John can bring only palm wine. (Therefore, he cannot bring other wines.)’

A narrow scope interpretation is also available with *nkoa*, but it is absent with *pɛ* and degraded in the doubling case.

³Renans (2017) observes that in Ga, the AwF possibilities of *tóó* ‘only’ and *pɛ* ‘only’ interact with indefinite determiners and number distinction (e.g., *tóó* exceptionally allows Det_{indef.} to combine with plural/mass nouns; *tóó* and *pɛ* differ in AwF with numerals/Det_{indef.}). We wish to note that no such interactions are observed for *nkoa* and *pɛ* in Akan. For the number system in Akan, see Ahenkorah (2026a,b) and references therein.

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- (10) Narrow scope under modals: *Today is John's graduation day. Everyone else needs to bring two types of alcohol, but John is exempt.* (◇>only)

- a. John be-tumi de nsa fufuo **nkoaa** a-ba.
 b. #John be-tumi de nsa fufuo **pɛ** a-ba.
 c. ?John be-tumi de nsa fufuo **nkoaa pɛ** a-ba.
 John can use wine white only only PFV-come
 (... Nanso ɔ be-tumi de nsa foforo a-ba nso.)
 but 3SG can use wine other PFV-come also

(a-c), Int.: 'John can bring only palm wine. (But he can also bring other wines.)'

The scopal ambiguities of *nkoaa* is similar to English adfocal *only*, which also has the two scopal possibilities (Taglicht 1984, Bassi et al. 2022, among others), as in (11).

- (11) Jill may bring **only**_{Adfoc} WINE. (Bassi et al. 2022:816)
 a. 'Jill is only allowed to bring wine.' (no beer, whisky, ...) (only>◇)
 b. 'Jill is allowed to only bring wine.' (she can bring beer if she wants) (◇>only)

Second, we discuss the interaction between scope and ellipsis, where a key difference between Akan and English arises. In Akan, when the focused constituent is elided together with adfocal particles, the wide scope reading survives. This holds for object ellipsis and for "do so" replacement, with *nkoaa*, *pɛ*, and their doubling, as in (12).

- (12) Wide scope is preserved with ellipsis: "*Palm wine day*" scenario in (9):
 a. John be-tumi de nsa fufuo {**nkoaa/ pɛ/ nkoaa pɛ**} a-ba.
 John can use wine white only only only PFV-come
 'John can only bring palm wine.' (only>◇)
 b. ... Mary nso be-tumi {de Δ a-ba/ a-yɛ saa}.
 Mary also can use PFV-come PFV-do that
 'Mary also can only bring palm wine.'

English adfocal *only*, in contrast, loses the wide-scope interpretation under ellipsis in (13), as insightfully observed by Bassi et al. (2022).

- (13) a. (Jill may bring **only**_{Adfoc} WINE.) Bill may Δ, too. (Bassi et al. 2022:816)
 b. ...# Therefore, Bill cannot bring beer. (*only>◇)
 c. ...Of course Bill can also bring beer if he likes. (◇>only)

Bassi et al. (2022) argue that adfocal *only* is not itself a D-quantifier, but instead signals the presence of a null counterpart of adverbial *only*, OP_{EXCL}. As shown in (14), adverbial *only* cannot associate into an ellipsis site (unless itself is also elided). Under the uniform operator view, the absence of wide scope under ellipsis in (13) is attributed to the constraint that OP_{EXCL}, higher than the modal (i.e., wide scope of exclusives), cannot associate with an elided focus, as schematized in (15).

(14) Focus association of *only* fails in VP ellipsis

A: I **only** know he brought WHITE_F wine. What about you?

a. B1: I **only** know he brought WHITE_F wine, too.

b. *B2: I **only** know he did ~~bring WHITE_F wine~~, too.

cf. B3: I do ~~only know he brought white_F wine~~, too.

cf. B4: I know he did ~~bring white wine~~, too.

(Bassi et al. 2022:817)

(15) a. *[Bill [**OP**_{EXCL} [may ~~bring only WINE~~]]] (*only>◇)

b. ^{OK}[Bill [may ~~OP_{EXCL} [bring only WINE]~~]] (◇>only)

By contrast, wide-scope interpretations derived by Quantifier Raising (QR) are preserved under ellipsis (Sag 1976, Fox 2000, Bassi et al. 2022):

(16) a. A boy is standing on **every building**. (every>a)

b. A girl is, too. (every>a) (Bassi et al. 2022:820)

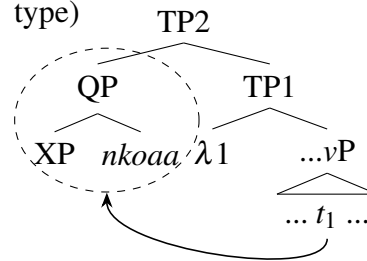
We conclude that at least in Akan, the exclusive semantics cannot be attributed to a null **OP**_{EXCL}, but must come from a (D-)quantifier realized as an adfocal particle (e.g., *nkoaa*), which may QR over modals. This conclusion challenges the uniform-operator view for Akan and distinguishes it from English. Given that *nkoaa* may associate with different categories of focus (cf. §3), the type-ambiguity view of exclusives is naturally called for.

5. A type-flexible analysis

In the spirit of the type-ambiguity view (e.g., Coppock and Beaver 2014), we propose a *type-flexible* analysis. We argue that *nkoaa* carries the exclusive semantics with flexible semantics types as generalized in (17), allowing for its cross-categorical uses. We further propose that it forms a QP with its focus associate (XP) and undergoes QR to the propositional level, leaving an abstracted variable whose type matches that of XP, as in (18). When XP has a higher-ordered type (e.g., properties), the trace's type is also higher-order (cf. Lechner 1999, Hirsch and Schwarz 2023, Poole and Keine 2024).

(17) $\llbracket nkoaa \rrbracket =$
 $\lambda \gamma \tau \lambda \mathbb{P}_{\langle \tau, t \rangle} . \forall \delta \tau [\mathbb{P}(\delta) \rightarrow \gamma = \delta];$
 where $\tau = e, \langle e, t \rangle, \langle s, t \rangle$, or $\langle et, t \rangle$

(18) LF: (type of variable abstracted = XP's type)



An illustration is given below for association with a DP object (with type *e*). *Nkoaa* forms a generalized quantifier $\langle et, t \rangle$ after taking the object, and excludes all the non-Mary

entities from the set of entities that are “seen by John” (*modulo* domain restriction), denoted by TP1 with the object trace lambda abstracted ($\langle e, t \rangle$).

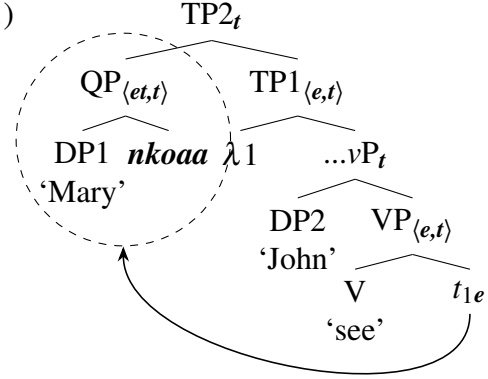
(19) John hu-u [Mary]_F **nkoa**. (Association with DP, cf. (1a))

John see-PST Mary only
‘John saw only Mary.’

(20) Composition (tense ignored)

- a. $\llbracket t \rrbracket = x$ (cf. $\llbracket \text{DP1} \rrbracket = m$)
- b. $\llbracket \text{VP} \rrbracket = \lambda z_e. \text{see}(z, x)$
- c. $\llbracket \text{vP} \rrbracket = \text{see}(j, x)$
- d. $\llbracket \text{TP1} \rrbracket = \lambda x_e. \text{see}(j, x)$
- e. $\llbracket \text{QP} \rrbracket = \lambda P_{\langle e, t \rangle}. \forall y_e [P(y) \rightarrow m = y]$
- f. $\llbracket \text{TP2} \rrbracket = \forall y_e [\text{see}(j, y) \rightarrow m = y]$

(21)



AwF with VP involves abstraction of a higher-order type $\langle e, t \rangle$ in TP1, resulting in a generalized quantifier type $\langle et, t \rangle$, which is a set of Mary’s properties. *Nkoa* takes a property (VP) and returns a quantifier over the generalized quantifier denoted by TP1 ($\langle \langle et, t \rangle, t \rangle$). It then excludes all the non-singing properties from the set of Mary’s properties (*modulo* domain restriction), yielding the reading “the only thing Mary did was singing”.

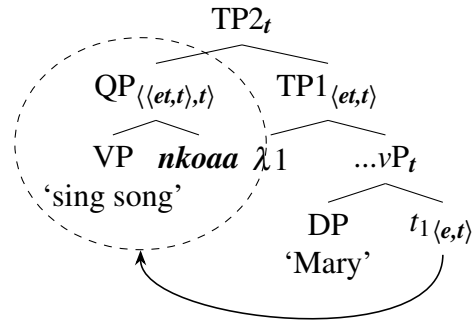
(22) Mary [tu-u nwom]_F **nkoa**. (Association with VP, cf. (5a))

Mary sing-PST song only
‘Mary only sang songs (and did not read books).’

(23) Composition (tense ignored)

- a. $\llbracket t \rrbracket = \lambda y_e. P(y)$
(cf. $\llbracket \text{VP} \rrbracket = \lambda y_e. \text{sing}(y)$)
- b. $\llbracket \text{vP} \rrbracket = P(m)$
- c. $\llbracket \text{TP1} \rrbracket = \lambda P_{\langle e, t \rangle}. P(m)$
- d. $\llbracket \text{QP} \rrbracket = \lambda \mathcal{P}_{\langle et, t \rangle}. \forall Q_{\langle e, t \rangle} [\mathcal{P}(Q) \rightarrow \lambda x_e. \text{sing}(x) = Q]$
- e. $\llbracket \text{TP2} \rrbracket = \forall Q_{\langle e, t \rangle} [Q(m) \rightarrow \lambda x_e. \text{sing}(x) = Q]$

(24)

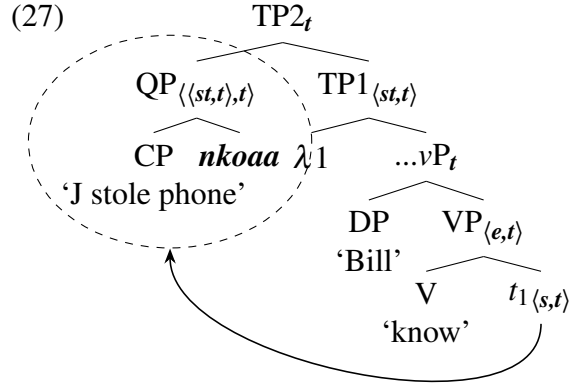


As shown below, AwF with CP similarly involves higher-order abstraction over propositions in the preadjacent TP1 and type-lifting QP to be a quantifier of sets of propositions.

(25) Bill nim [sɛ John wiaa phone]_F **nkoa**. (Association with CP, cf. (7a))

Bill know COMP John stole phone only
‘Bill only knows John stole a phone.’ (but doesn’t know Mary smoked cigarette)

- (26) Composition (tense ignored)
- a. $\llbracket t \rrbracket = p$ (cf. $\llbracket CP \rrbracket = \wedge John.steal.phone$)
 - b. $\llbracket VP \rrbracket = \lambda z_e.know(z, p)$
 - c. $\llbracket vP \rrbracket = know(b, p)$
 - d. $\llbracket TP1 \rrbracket = \lambda p_{\langle s,t \rangle}.know(b, p)$
 - e. $\llbracket QP \rrbracket = \lambda \mathcal{Q}_{\langle \langle s,t \rangle, t \rangle} . \forall q_{\langle s,t \rangle} [\mathcal{Q}(q) \rightarrow \wedge John.steal.phone = q]$
 - f. $\llbracket TP2 \rrbracket = \forall q_{\langle s,t \rangle} [know(b, q) \rightarrow \wedge John.steal.phone = q]$



Turning to $p\epsilon$, we suggest that it is, at least on the at-issue level, a truth-conditionally vacuous particle that is also type-flexible, as in (28). We borrow the insight from the uniform operator view (e.g., Quek and Hirsch 2017), with a refinement, that it agrees either with *nkoa* or with a null D-quantifier QU_{EXCL} , rather than an A-quantifier OP_{EXCL} (cf. Yip and Adedjei 2024, Yip 2026 for a similar view on Yoruba). The latter is responsible for exclusivity in cases where only $p\epsilon$ appears.⁴

- (28) $\llbracket p\epsilon \rrbracket = \lambda \Gamma_{\langle \langle \tau, t \rangle, t \rangle} . \Gamma$; where $\tau = e, \langle e, t \rangle, \langle s, t \rangle$, or $\langle et, t \rangle$

- (29) a. Singleton $p\epsilon$ cases: $\llbracket [QP DP_F QU_{EXCL}] p\epsilon \rrbracket$
 b. Doubling cases: $\llbracket [QP XP_F nkoa] p\epsilon \rrbracket$

Importantly, we assume that QU_{EXCL} is type-*inflexible* and always has the type $\langle e, \langle et, t \rangle \rangle$, unlike *nkoa*. This difference explains why $p\epsilon$ alone cannot associate with VP and CP—even when they are nominalized—because they do not denote entities (type e). In doubling cases, *nkoa* is type-flexible and hence AwF with VP and CP is possible again with $p\epsilon$.

- (30) $\llbracket QU_{EXCL} \rrbracket = \lambda x_e . \lambda P_{\langle e, t \rangle} . \forall y [P(y) \rightarrow y = x]$

6. Conclusion

To conclude, we have argued for the type-ambiguity view over the uniform operator view of exclusives for Akan, where only adfocal particles are attested. A type-flexible analysis of Akan exclusives is proposed, based on novel evidence from cross-categorical focus association and the survival of wide scope under ellipsis. We have also offered an account of exclusive doubling of *nkoa* and $p\epsilon$ that explains their asymmetries in AwF possibilities. The findings not only suggest that exclusives can be type-flexible (resonating Coppock and Beaver 2014’s view on English) with higher-order quantification and abstraction (e.g., Poole and Keine 2024), but also support Yip (2026)’s claim that whether a language has A-quantification or D-quantification in the domain of exclusives should be parameterized.

⁴We note that $p\epsilon$ is not entirely semantically vacuous, but has scalar contribution on the not-at-issue level. For space reasons, we cannot fully develop the account of $p\epsilon$ here, but we refer the readers to Yip (2024, 2026)’s scalar focus approach that can be extended to Akan with adaption.

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